

CORE FORMULA

Base: "I agree with [true part]. Where I see it differently is [specific disagreement]. My reason is [brief reason]. I'd suggest [next step]." -> **Short:** "I agree with the goal. I disagree with the method." -> **Boundary:** "I understand why that feels urgent. I'm not comfortable doing it that way." -> **Feedback:** "You're right that speed matters. The part I'd challenge is the idea that speed means skipping review." -> **Digital:** "Agreed on the problem. I see a different cause. Could we test that before deciding?"

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Before you say "I disagree," name one real point of agreement in a single sentence.

BEST FOR

- Workplace dissent and productive disagreement
- Feedback and performance conversations
- Negotiation and objection handling
- Family disagreement where the relationship matters
- Group decisions that need real dissent, not face-saving compliance
- Mixed-truth moments: one reasonable concern, a conclusion you don't share
- Online replies and conflict de-escalation

PHRASE BANK

Quick openers · One-line splits

- "I agree with the aim. I differ on the route."
- "Agreed on the goal. Not on the method."
- "Yes to the what — let me flag the how."
- "You're right about that part. The next part I'd separate."
- "I'm with you on the problem. Less sure on the fix."
- "Agree on the symptom. Not yet on the cause."
- "Same page on the why. Different read on the timing."
- "I'm with you up to a point — here's where I split off."

Social and everyday · Family, friends, rapport

- "I agree that it felt frustrating. I see the choice itself a little differently."
- "You're right that the timing was bad. Where I differ is whether they meant it as an insult."
- "I agree the situation felt unfair. I read the intention behind it differently."
- "I can see why that landed badly. I'm just not sure it was aimed at you."
- "You've got a real point there. The bit I'd gently push back on is one detail."
- "I'm with you that it mattered. I just land somewhere else on what to do next."
- "I get why you're annoyed, and I'd have been too. Where I see it differently is whose call it was."

Work and meetings · Decisions, feedback, status

- "I agree with the objective. I don't agree that this plan is the safest route to it."
- "The risk you named is real. My concern is that the proposed fix creates a second risk."
- "I agree the draft has energy. The part I'd work on is the structure."
- "I agree the presentation had strong examples. The opening is what I'd challenge."
- "It sounds like we're aligned on the timeline. The budget is where I'd pause."

- "I agree we need a decision today. I'm not convinced we have enough to make it irreversible."
- "You're right that speed matters here. What I'd challenge is that speed means skipping review."

Clear dissent with a next step · Name the split, offer the move

- "I agree the goal is right. Where I differ is shipping without review — I'd suggest a 30-minute blocker-only pass."
- "The part I agree with is that the handoff was unclear. The part I won't accept is that the whole delay sits with one person."
- "I agree cost matters. I can't agree to that price without changing the scope."
- "I agree the scope grew. I can't hold the same timeline unless we drop lower-priority work."
- "I want to separate those: I agree with X, not with Y."
- "I agree with the concern. I question the conclusion, and I'd propose a different next step."
- "Could we test both assumptions before we decide?"

Pressure and boundaries · Urgency, safety, firm limits

- "I understand the urgency. I'm not willing to skip the check that protects everyone."
- "I understand why you want a quick answer. I'm not comfortable committing before I check the details."
- "I agree delay has costs. I also think an irreversible call without review costs more."
- "You're right that people are waiting. I still won't skip the step that keeps us safe."
- "I hear that this feels urgent, and the line for me is doing it without a review."
- "I agree we're under pressure. That's the reason I want the check, not the reason to drop it."

Repair and reset · After a token yes

- "That sounded like a token yes before a no. Let me say the agreement more clearly."
- "I made my disagreement sound larger than it is. We agree on the aim; I only differ on the next step."
- "I don't want my disagreement to erase the part you got right."
- "Let me restart: I agree that X matters. I just don't think Y follows from it."
- "That came out as a setup. I did mean the first part."
- "I accepted one part too quickly — let me separate what I can agree with from what I can't."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: "I disagree." Clear but broad — it makes the other person defend their whole position.

Better: "I agree with the goal, but I disagree with the plan." This separates aim from method, though "but" can still feel like cancellation.

Best: "I agree with the goal: we need this resolved today. Where I differ is shipping without review — a 30-minute review protects the deadline better than a rollback tomorrow."

2. Weak: "That's not true."

Better: "Part of that is true."

Best: "The part I agree with is that the handoff was unclear. The part I would not accept is that the whole delay sits with one person."

3. Weak: "Your draft needs work."

Better: "The draft is good, but the structure is off."

Best: "I agree the draft has real energy. The one thing I'd rework is the structure, so the point lands sooner."

DECISION TREE

If There's no part you honestly agree with.

Don't fake it. Disagree respectfully and go straight to your reason.

"I see this differently, and here's why."

If The other person is emotionally activated.

Validate the concern first, then make the agreement/disagreement split.

"I can see this really matters to you. Can I show you where I land?"

If The disagreement is about facts.

Agree with the shared observation, then present the evidence or the uncertainty.

"We're seeing the same result. I read the cause differently — could we check?"

If The disagreement is about values.

Agree with the value you share, then name the competing value or tradeoff.

"I care about that too. I'm weighing it against the risk on the other side."

If The disagreement is about a request.

Agree with the real need, then state the boundary or an alternative.

"The need makes sense. I can't do it that way, but I can offer this."

If They treat your agreement as full consent.

Clarify the split and re-name the contested piece.

"I want to separate those: I agree with X, not with Y."

SCENARIOS

A workplace plan under deadline

Accept the pressure and the shared goal, narrow the disagreement to the method, offer a lighter path. — "I agree the deadline matters. I disagree that skipping QA is the fastest path — I'd suggest a blocker-only review."

Feedback on someone's work

Name a genuine strength, then challenge one specific part. — "I agree the examples were strong. The part I'd challenge is the opening — it took too long to reach the point."

Negotiation on scope and price

Agree the constraint is real, then tie your limit to a clear tradeoff. — "I agree the scope increased. I can't hold the same timeline unless we remove lower-priority work."

Family conflict

Accept the feeling, differ on the interpretation. — "I agree the situation felt unfair. I see the intention behind it differently."

An online or public reply

Concede the shared observation, keep the contested point to one, invite a test. — "Agreed on the problem. I'm less convinced by the cause — the data could also fit another explanation."

Someone pushing for a quick yes

Acknowledge the pull for speed, then hold a clean boundary. — "I understand why you want a quick answer. I'm not comfortable committing before I check the details."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- The agreement would be false — you don't actually accept any part.
- A boundary has already been crossed, or someone is unsafe.
- The other person is using bad-faith pressure.
- A fast, direct correction is what the moment requires.
- You would be using it as a pacifier to avoid naming the real issue.
- Physical safety or an immediate emergency takes priority.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the true yes

Through the day, catch three disagreements (yours or other people's). For each, write down the one part you could genuinely accept.

Day 2 — Split the statement

Take a disagreement you expect this week. Make two columns — "part I genuinely agree with" and "part I contest" — and speak one sentence from each.

Day 3 — Replace "but"

Rewrite five "I agree, but?" lines using "and," "where I differ," or a full stop, so the yes survives the sentence.

Day 4 — One-point dissent

Respond to a complex claim with only one contested point. Notice the urge to stack objections, and drop the extras.

Day 5 — Add the reason and the next step

Take yesterday's dissent and finish the formula: one brief reason, then one concrete next step or test.

Day 6 — Recovery rehearsal

Practise aloud: "That sounded like a token yes. Let me separate it more cleanly," until it sounds natural rather than scripted.

Day 7 — Live review

Use the move in one real disagreement, then score yourself 0/1 on: real agreement, specific dissent, brief reason, respectful next step.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I name a real point of agreement, not a fake softener?
- Was the agreement specific enough that they could recognise it?
- Did I keep the agreement from implying full consent?
- Was my disagreement narrow — one behavioural, factual or decision-specific point?
- Did I bridge with "and" or "where I differ" rather than a cancelling "but"?
- Did I give one reason and a next step without lecturing?